

Chapter 35 Part 3

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Lunchtime.

Sally's gossiping soul was completely unstoppable. She ran to Xu Qingzhu's office and asked again and again.

Xu Qingzhu sighed helplessly: "Cherry, manage her."

Lin Luoxi scoffed lightly: "Can't manage her. She's a wild horse that's broken free of its reins."

Afterward, Xu Qingzhu was bothered to the point where she had no choice but to briefly tell Sally about the grudges between herself and Zhou Yi'an.

After listening, Sally summarized only one point: Zhou Yi'an was Xu Qingzhu's romantic rival.

"OMG. You and Liang Shi are already married, yet the mistress still won't give up! Did she find no breakthrough with Liang Shi, so she came to cause trouble for you?" Sally crossed her arms, anxious like an ant on a hot pan. "The mistress has come right to your doorstep, and you're still this calm? Blanche! Put down those documents!"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She rubbed her forehead helplessly. "What's mine can't be taken away, what's not mine can't be kept."

Sally: "..."

She poked Lin Luoxi: "What does that mean?"

Lin Luoxi was eating, stuck her chopsticks into her rice, and explained viciously in English: "It means even if you wanted to leave back then, I could tie steel bars to your legs and you'd still be able to walk away."

Sally: "..."

Sally shrank her neck, not daring to provoke Lin Luoxi further, and continued talking to Xu Qingzhu: "Blanche, this calls for war."

"What war?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I checked the information. Zhou Yi'an is indeed RT's annual emerging designer, and during her year at ME¹, two of ME's hit products were designed by her."

"Is Mr. Zhou..." Lin Luoxi pointed at the ceiling, speaking vaguely: "That one?"

"Yes." Xu Qingzhu smiled bitterly. "How many Mr. Zhous are there in all of Haichuan City?"

However, fortunately, Mr. Zhou wasn't completely muddle-headed either.

Even if he doted on Zhou Yi'an, there were limits.

She heard that after the last banquet, Zhou Yi'an was confined.

And Mr. Zhou was very angry, directly freezing her cards. No matter how much Mrs. Zhou pleaded, it was useless.

"Then according to this, she's completely untouchable." Lin Luoxi was worried. "You and Liang Shi won't really get divorced because of her, will you?"

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a few seconds, then said very seriously: "Even if Liang Shi and I divorce someday, it won't be because of Zhou Yi'an."

Their divorce was already a foregone conclusion anyway.

Sally, as a desperate gossip-eating creature, couldn't get her fill due to the language barrier and was extremely anxious.

She began to regret: "I should have studied more Chinese when I was in school."

Lin Luoxi scoffed: "You've been in China for four years and your Chinese level is still this garbage. If Chinese had proficiency tests, you probably couldn't even pass level two."

Sally: "It's because Chinese is too difficult! Pinyin² is too hard to learn."

Sally and Lin Luoxi began their daily bickering.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu buried her head in signing documents, then took time to send her father a message, asking if he was at the company and wanting to meet with him.

She needed to figure out why Zhou Yi'an came to Minghui.

"Blanche," Sally said to Xu Qingzhu after she and Lin Luoxi had called a truce. "From now on, don't let Liang Shi drive you to the company, and don't let her pick you up either. Otherwise, it'll create opportunities for her and the mistress to meet. This is called..."

She racked her brains to think of an idiom: "Nurturing a tiger to invite disaster."³

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Got it."

However—

"Sally, don't use such terms in the company from now on, and don't bring private matters to work." Xu Qingzhu said. "The company is the company. If Zhou Yi'an really has talent, then I will definitely make the best use of her abilities. I don't want my personal affairs to affect the company's development."

Especially now that the company was already struggling.

If Zhou Yi'an's arrival could change the current predicament, she wouldn't mind either.

She only started eating after finishing the documents, but halfway through her meal, she received a reply from Xu Guangyao saying he was there and she could come over anytime.

Xu Qingzhu casually ate a few more bites, then greeted Lin Luoxi and hurriedly left the office.

While going upstairs, she even encountered Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an was holding an iced Americano⁴ and nodded to Xu Qingzhu with a teasing tone: "Little cutie, where are you going?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned: "It's none of your business."

The elevator door opened. Before stepping into the elevator, Xu Qingzhu stopped and said very seriously: "Don't call me by that kind of name."

Zhou Yi'an: "What kind?"

She thought Xu Qingzhu would fall for it, but Xu Qingzhu said expressionlessly: "The kind you just used."

She said: "I'm afraid I'll throw up even last night's midnight snack."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Then I'm truly sorry." Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow. "I thought you were also someone with... romantic flair."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, like a spring breeze, then restrained her smile, her voice much gentler than before.

Zhou Yi'an was puzzled: "Is it that funny?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Sorry, I'm not laughing at you."

A smile appeared on her face, which perfectly blended bright beauty and pure innocence. "I just thought of my wife. I'm not someone without romantic flair either."

When mentioning Liang Shi, Zhou Yi'an's smile immediately disappeared completely.

Her level was still relatively low - she couldn't yet achieve the composure of remaining unmoved even if Mount Tai collapsed before her.

Xu Qingzhu continued: "But I usually only have romantic flair with my wife, like calling her 'darling wife.'"

When saying those last four words, Xu Qingzhu's voice rose at the end, sounding particularly intimate and tinged with some ambiguity.

Especially when spoken in her slightly cold voice, it made people's thoughts wander and imagination run wild.

Zhou Yi'an's iced Americano cup was somewhat deformed in her grip.

Xu Qingzhu's smile didn't diminish, her voice still gentle: "Our romantic flair is never displayed outside, especially not in a place like the company. Even if my wife were standing here, I wouldn't play such romantic games with her. Moreover, I think romantic flair should only be played with someone you love to be meaningful. What do you think, Miss Zhou?"

Zhou Yi'an: "You!"

She said one word through gritted teeth before being interrupted by Xu Qingzhu: "Otherwise it easily becomes workplace sexual harassment."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"I'll go first." Xu Qingzhu said. "Designer Zhou, work hard."

Zhou Yi'an finally couldn't hold back: "Xu Qingzhu, you really are sharp-tongued."

The elevator door slowly closed, and Xu Qingzhu maintained a faint smile throughout.

Zhou Yi'an was so angry her face was almost distorted.

Damn it!

F*ck.

Zhou Yi'an stood there, her mind filled with nothing but curse words.

This was clearly showing off to her!

"Wife" this, "wife" that - hah.

She hadn't seen them being so lovey-dovey before, but now they were putting on an act, weren't they?

But it was still because Liang Shi was too partial to her.

The favored naturally acted without restraint.

The elevator opened again, and a group of new colleagues who had just finished eating outside saw the new designer with an expression like she'd eaten sh*t.

Someone boldly tried to make conversation: "Designer Zhou, have you eaten?"

Only then did Zhou Yi'an come back to her senses. Without thinking, she answered angrily: "Eat sh*t!"

Then she grabbed her iced Americano and returned to her workstation.

Leaving everyone standing there in confusion: "..."

So the new designer had such unique tastes.

Footnotes:

1. **ME:** A prestigious international design company mentioned in previous chapters.
2. **Pinyin (拼音):** The official romanization system for Standard Chinese, used to teach pronunciation of Chinese characters.
3. **"Nurturing a tiger to invite disaster" (養虎為患):** A Chinese idiom meaning to shelter a potential threat that will eventually cause harm.
4. **Iced Americano:** A popular coffee drink, showing Zhou Yi'an's westernized tastes.